

TALKING YOUR WAY TO PEACE

Communication is one of the foundational building blocks of your marriage relationship. How do you get to know each other without communication? How can you express yourself without words; how can you resolve differences without talking? The Bible has a lot to say about communication and the words you use, for positive and negative. We'll be studying some of those scriptures in this lesson. If you apply yourself to understanding and doing what the Bible instructs concerning words, you'll reap the reward of a strifeless, harmonious, peaceful, and unified marriage.

Communication is more than talking at someone. Communication is expressing your thoughts, feelings, opinions, and ideas in such a way that causes the other person to understand. Communication is not just talking, but a combination of talking and listening. If you have one without the other, then you do not have communication.

Communication is defined as: "a giving or exchanging of information", also "the art of expressing ideas".

Listening is defined as: "to hear something with thoughtful attention".

There are different levels of communication. The first is describing the fundamental level at which nearly everyone communicates. This level consists of: "Hi, how are you?" "Nice day, today." "Did you have a good day at work?" "I read an interesting article in the paper today." Almost anyone can engage in this level of communication.

As our communication develops, we reach the level that is described in the second definition - "The art of expressing ideas" (we could also include 'feelings'). This is the level where real communication begins. As the definition says, it is an art, which means it takes time, practice, and patience to develop. At this level, where you are opening yourself up in order to express your feelings and ideas, you run the risk of being rejected or belittled; therefore, many people are fearful of this level of communication. But with all the right ingredients to communication, this level can be, and must be, reached in order for your marriage to become strong and for both of you to be fulfilled in the relationship.

Let's examine the next crucial component of effective communication: listening. Here's the definition again: "to hear something with thoughtful attention". This isn't describing listening to someone with one ear and to something else with the other ear. If you're really paying attention to what you're hearing, then you can't be talking, reading or watching something else. Your attention is on the person and what they are saying.

James 1:19,20 says, *"Understand this, my beloved brethren, let every man be quick to hear, a ready listener, slow to speak, slow to take offense and to get angry.... For man's anger does not promote the righteousness of God."* God is saying that it's better to do more listening than speaking. Notice that this translation says we are to be 'a ready listener'. We can compare it to a runner. When a runner lines up for the race, he takes his mark and the official yells, "On your mark, get ready"! Every muscle in that runner, every thought, his whole attention is straining to hear the sound of the gun. The same should be true when we're listening to our spouse – we must be 'ready' to hear what they have to say.

Proverbs 18:13 says, *"He who answers a matter before he hears the facts, it is folly and shame to him."* When your future spouse is talking to you, be ready to listen to their complete thought before you give a response. Don't finish their sentences for them or put words in their mouth. It is just good manners and a show of respect to let them finish expressing themselves.

Answer the following questions:

1. How do you know when a person is listening to you?

2. What response do you like your future partner to give to show that he/she is really listening?

3. How do you show that you are listening?

There are other ingredients that will benefit your communication. One of them is timing. More can be accomplished with a few words at the right time than with many words at the wrong time. Proverbs 15:23-28 says, *"A man has joy by the answer of his mouth, and a word spoken in due season (in its time), how good it is." "The heart of the righteous studies how to answer, but the mouth of the wicked pours forth evil."* Consider the timing for the things you want to say. If it's something really important that will take some discussion, it may be best to make an appointment so you will have uninterrupted time together. Before your discussion, think about what you want to say and how you want to say it. Proverbs 16:23 says, *"The heart of the wise teaches his mouth, and adds learning to his lips."*

Look up the following scriptures and answer the questions:

TRUE

FALSE

Proverbs 10:19

1. The more you talk, the more opportunity there is to sin.

James 1:19

2. Some people were made to listen; others were made to talk.
3. There should never be any silent spots in your conversation.

Proverbs 13:3

4. You will keep yourself from trouble and needless hurt if you watch what comes out of your mouth.

Proverbs 15:28

5. It's okay to say anything and everything that comes to your mind.

Proverbs 17:28

6. What you say is evidence of what you are, i.e., foolish, wise, etc.

Proverbs 15:23

7. There is no such thing as "the right word at the right time".

Proverbs 16:24

8. Angry words will bring healing to body and soul.

Proverbs 16:21,23

9. Our choice of words makes a difference in how people receive what we say.

Proverbs 18:13

10. There is a time to listen and a time to talk.

Another ingredient for good communication is honesty. Your marriage will only benefit when you speak the truth and speak it in love. Ephesians 4:25 says, *"Therefore, putting away lying, each one speak truth with his neighbour, for we are members of one another."* Verse 15 tells us we are to speak the truth in love. Colossians 3:9 says, *"Do not lie to one another, since you have put off the old man with his deeds."* Lying has no place in your life now, to any degree. If you are fearful or unsure of your partner's response to certain situations, you may be tempted to hold back the whole truth. This is deception -- causing a person to think only what you want them to by withholding some of the facts. A marriage has to have total honesty and sincerity in order to be strong. Proverbs 8:7-8 says, *"For my mouth will speak truth; wickedness is an abomination to my lips. All the words of my mouth are with righteousness; nothing crooked or perverse is in them."*

Also, in order to have honest communication, you must say what you mean and mean what you say. Words are very important, and you are accountable for your words. In your communication, your words must be sincere and accurate. You must be a person of your word, first to God, then to your spouse, then to all others. Being a person who does what he says builds trust and reliability.

Answer the following questions:

1. Is there total honesty in the communication between you and your future spouse?

2. Are there any areas that are "touchy" or uncomfortable for you and your future spouse to talk about? If so, write down the area or areas.

3. What do you perceive is the stumbling block in this area or areas?

4. Do you use "shut off" phrases such as: 'I don't want to talk about it'; 'I can't talk about it now'; 'I've said all I'm going to say'; etc.?

5. Are you aware of your future spouse using these phrases?

6. When you communicate with your future spouse, can you talk:

very easily

easily

with some difficulty

with great difficulty

Words are not the only means of communication. Experts tell us that only 7% of our message is expressed through words; 35% of our message comes from our tone of voice, and 58% is sent through body language - eye contact, facial expressions, etc. In order to have clear communication, every part of us needs to be sending the same message. James 5:12 says, *"Let your 'yes' be yes and your 'no' be no, or you will be condemned."* There are some couples who play a 'double meaning' game. They will say one thing with their mouth, but their expression or tone of voice says something else. This causes confusion and opens the door to strife. As it says in Proverbs 16:23, let your heart teach your mouth, so you can give a clear answer, because *'out of the abundance of the heart the mouth speaks.'* (Matthew 12:34)

Answer the following questions:

1. Read Ephesians 4:29

Make a list of what you believe are unwholesome or negative words or phrases; maybe some that you find yourself using.

2. Make a list of wholesome or positive words or phrases.

3. Read Proverbs 12:14 and 13:2

What fills or satisfies a man with good and brings him enjoyment?

4. According to Proverbs 18:21 and 12:18, what can destroy and what can bring healing?

Because your words are to edify and minister grace, you should not use them for criticism or blame. In order to have open, good communication in your marriage, it must be based on love and acceptance. Romans 14:13 says, *"Then let us no more criticize and blame and pass judgement on one another, but rather decide and endeavor never to put a stumbling block or an obstacle or a hindrance in the way of a brother."* 1 Thessalonians 5:11 says, *"Therefore encourage, admonish, exhort one another and edify - strengthen and build up - one another, just as you are doing."* You must eliminate criticism and blame from your conversation, no matter how deserved it might be. When you want to criticize, God says to edify. When you want to blame, He tells you to exhort.

I Peter 3:9 says, *"Never return evil for evil or insult for insult - scolding tongue-lashing, berating; but on the contrary blessing -- praying for their welfare, happiness and protection, and truly pitying and loving them. For know that to this you have been called, that you may yourselves inherit a blessing (from God) -- obtain a blessing as heirs, bringing welfare and happiness and protection."* God says you were called to render a blessing, and you yourself will inherit a blessing. Use your communication to render a blessing.

RESOLVING DIFFERENCES

The original title of this lesson was 'Resolving Conflicts'. The title changed when we realised the severity of the word 'conflict'. The definition of conflict is: "to be antagonistic, incompatible or contradictory; sharp disagreement, as of interests or ideas." The root words for conflict are "to strike together". If there is this type of strife in your relationship now, you shouldn't be thinking about getting married.

On the other hand, everyone has disagreements and differences of opinion; therefore, this is the direction this lesson will go - teaching you how to resolve your differences, how to disagree agreeably, and how to eliminate strife in your relationship.

Everyone has an opinion - and everyone thinks theirs is right. What do you do when you and your future spouse's opinions are different? The manner in which you resolve these differences will be the determining factor in whether there is strife or peace in your relationship. One thing you must realise, you will not agree on everything, but on major issues you must come into agreement or reach a compromise.

1. What do you feel are minor issues that you may not agree about?

2. What do you feel are major issues that you must agree upon?

Recognising what causes strife is the first step in eliminating it. Proverbs 13:10 says, *"By pride comes only contention,"*. James 4:1 says, *"Where do wars and fights come from among you? Do they not come from your desires for pleasure that war in your members?"* You can see from these scriptures that basically strife comes from selfishness - being self-seeking and demanding your own rights and way. You must be willing to put aside your rights and opinions and be willing to listen to reason. James 3:13-18 shows you the difference between fleshly wisdom and godly wisdom.

There are many principles that you can employ to resolve your differences. We'll discuss several of them here.

The foundation principle is communication. In the previous lesson, you learned the importance of communication. You must be able to sit down and talk about your differences. A peaceable, reasonable conversation will bear much fruit in the situation. Proverbs 15:1 says, *"A soft answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."* Different people react in different ways when faced with disagreements. Some try to ignore or avoid disagreement; some become withdrawn and silent; some pout; some become harsh and angry and raise their voice.

1. How do you respond to disagreement?

2. How does your future spouse respond?

3. What do you believe is a scriptural way of handling disagreements?

Another important factor in resolving differences is timing. You cannot control the time or place when disagreements may occur, but you can control the timing when you are able to sit down and talk it through. Read the fifth chapter of Esther, and it will show you how she prepared herself, the setting and the timing for her appeal to the King. If at all possible, prepare the time and setting for your discussion. Agree on a time when you'll sit down and talk, uninterrupted; then in the meantime, pray - make sure your attitude is right; ask God to give you a hearing ear and to put His words in your mouth. When you come together, remember this very important point: attack the problem and not each other. Make statements of fact, not accusations or suppositions. Your ultimate goal is to resolve the problem, bring strength to your relationship and build each other up.

1. What are some issues that you frequently disagree about?

2. Have you been able to sit down and talk about them and come to an agreement?

3. If not, what do you feel is the stumbling block?

4. Do you feel that you are a willing listener to your future spouse's point of view? Explain why.

5. Does your future spouse agree? Why or why not?

6. Do you feel your future spouse has good timing when he/she wants to talk about a disagreement? Why or why not?

7. Do you feel that your future spouse accuses or criticises you when you have a difference of opinion? If yes, explain how.

Another principle to employ is to offer solutions not just criticisms. If you've talked about some changes that need to be made, be prepared to give some solutions. Many people offer ultimatums, "Do this or else.....". God's way is to offer solutions. You not only want to accomplish agreement, but you also want to strengthen your relationship by making godly changes when necessary.

What do you do when you reach an impasse - when it seems like you are at such opposites that you'll never agree? Here are four points to help you break that impasse:

1. Don't let strife accelerate.

A. Proverbs 29:11, *"A fool vents all his feelings, but a wise man holds them back."*

B. Proverbs 21:23, *"Whoever guards his mouth and tongue keeps his soul from troubles."*

C. Proverbs 10:19, *"In the multitude of words sin is not lacking, but he who restrains his lips is wise."*

2. Go to your separate corners to cool off - pray.

Proverbs 16:32, *"He who is slow to anger is better than the mighty, and he who rules his spirit than he who takes a city."*

3. Read the Word - see if you can find the answer.

4. In times of peace, agree that you will seek godly counsel at times of impasse.

A. Proverbs 11:14, *"in the multitude of counselors there is safety."*

B. Proverbs 24:6, *"For by wise counsel you will wage your own war, and in a multitude of counselors there is safety."*

1. Do you feel there are any major areas where you and your future spouse have not reached an agreement? If so, what areas?

2. Do you feel it's important to reach an agreement before you're married? Why or why not?

3. How does your future spouse feel about it?

Remember that communication is one of the most important elements in your relationship. If you have developed a good foundation in your communication, it will make it easier to resolve your differences.